

Lesson 7: Proposals, Communication, and Delivery

What You're Learning and Why

You already have a priced service package (from Lessons 3–4) and you know how to find opportunities safely and what marketplace rules apply to your age (Lessons 5–6). This lesson is about the moment right before you get hired: what do you actually say to a client?

A **proposal** is the message that turns "someone needs help" into "you have a job." Get it right and clients trust you immediately. Get it vague or oversold, and even a great service package won't land the work.

You'll also learn how to talk to clients like a professional while the work is happening, and how to properly finish and hand off a job. In Lesson 8, you'll use everything from this lesson in a full, timed Client Simulation — so treat what you write today as something you might actually send to a real client.

The Proposal Structure Formula

Every strong proposal has five parts. Memorize the order — it works because it builds trust before it asks for money.

Part	What it does	Length
1. Understanding of Need	Restate the client's request in your own words	1–2 sentences
2. My Approach	Briefly explain how you'll do the work	2–3 sentences
3. What's Included	Exact list of deliverables	Bullet list
4. Price	One clear number (or simple range)	1 line
5. Timeline	Specific date or day-count	1 line

Optional add-on: **Next Steps** — what the client should do to confirm.

Why "Understanding of Need" comes first: it proves you actually read their message instead of sending a copy-paste pitch, and it gives them a chance to correct you before you've built anything.

Why "What's Included" matters most for avoiding problems later: if it's not on the list, it's not part of the job. This is your main tool for preventing arguments about scope after you've started.

Professional Communication Norms

Tone: clear, warm, concise

Not stiff, not overly casual. Compare:

Too stiff	Too casual	Right tone
"Per your request, please find enclosed my proposed terms of engagement."	"heyyy so basically i can do this np just venmo me whenever lol"	"Hi Alex — happy to help with this! Here's how I'd approach it, plus pricing and timeline below."

Response time expectations

Being professional isn't about replying instantly — it's about being **predictable**. Decide your real response window (e.g., "evenings and weekends, since I'm in school during the day") and say it once, early. A client who knows what to expect will not worry when they don't hear back in ten minutes.

Setting expectations early

Say your constraints out loud before they become a problem: "Just a heads up — I check messages evenings after school, so I usually reply within 24 hours." One sentence, said once, prevents most misunderstandings.

Asking clarifying questions

Format: **acknowledge, then ask one specific question at a time.**

- Good: "Thanks for reaching out! Quick question before I put a proposal together — do you want the logo redesigned too, or just the flyer?"
- Weak: "What do you want it to look like, what's your budget, when do you need it, what colors, is there a deadline?" (five vague questions at once reads as if you haven't thought about it yet)

How to say no or negotiate scope politely

Three-part script: 1. Thank them. 2. State the boundary plainly. 3. Offer an alternative, if one exists.

Example (declining work outside your skills): *"Thanks for thinking of me for this! A full website redesign is outside what I offer right now — I mainly do social media graphics. I'd be happy to help with the graphics piece if that's useful."*

Example (scope creep mid-project): *"Happy to add those extra revisions — since that's beyond what we originally scoped, it'd be an additional \$10 and one extra day. Want me to go ahead?"*

Worked Example: A Fictional Proposal

Client's message: *"Hi! I run a small dog-walking business in my neighborhood and I need a flyer to hand out and post online. Nothing fancy, just something that looks nice. How much would that be?"*

Proposal sent back:

Hi there,

Thanks for reaching out! Here's what I understand and how I'd approach it:

Understanding of Need: You'd like a flyer for your dog-walking business that works both as a printed handout and as a social media post.

My Approach: I'll design one flyer in Canva using a friendly, readable layout, then send you two color/style variations to choose between before finalizing.

What's Included: - One flyer design, sized for both print (8.5x11") and Instagram post - Two style options to choose between - Up to 2 rounds of revisions - Final files in PDF (for printing) and PNG (for posting online)

Price: \$25

Timeline: Draft options within 3 days of you confirming; final files within 2 days after you pick a style.

Next Steps: Just reply "yes" and let me know your business name, phone number, and any colors you'd like, and I'll get started!

Thanks, [Your name]

Notice: no exclamation-point overselling about how "amazing" it will be — just a specific, honest plan.

Step-by-Step Activity: Draft Your Own Proposal

1. Open the Worksheet.md proposal template (or a fresh Google Doc).
2. Pick one sample client ask (your instructor will assign one, or use your own L3–4 service package as the basis).
3. Write your **Understanding of Need** in 1–2 sentences — restate the ask in your own words.
4. Write your **My Approach** in 2–3 sentences.
5. Build your **What's Included** as a specific bullet list.
6. Write your **Price** as one plain number.
7. Write your **Timeline** as a specific date or day-count — no "soon."
8. Add a **Next Steps** line telling the client what to do to confirm.
9. Read the whole thing aloud. Does it sound clear, warm, and concise — like a competent person, not a sales ad and not a text to a friend?
10. Save your draft — you'll reuse this structure in Lesson 8's Client Simulation.

Key Terms

- **Proposal** — a structured message offering to do specific work for a specific price and timeline, sent in response to a client's request.
- **Scope negotiation** — the polite back-and-forth of adjusting what work is included, and for what price, when a request changes or grows.
- **Handoff** — the process of delivering finished work to a client along with any instructions they need to use it, and formally closing out the job.
- **Professional tone** — communication that is clear, warm, and concise — neither stiff/formal nor overly casual.

Knowledge Checks

1. What are the five parts of a proposal, in order?
2. Why should "Understanding of Need" come before price?
3. A client asks for two extra rounds of revisions after you already agreed on scope. What's the polite three-part way to respond?
4. True or False: Replying to a client within 5 minutes is always more professional than replying within a day. Explain your answer.
5. Rewrite this line so it matches a professional tone (not stiff, not overly casual): "yo i can def do this, itll look SO good trust me!!"

Reflection Prompts

1. Which part of the proposal structure (Understanding of Need, Approach, What's Included, Price, Timeline) do you think you'll naturally forget to include, and why?
2. Think of a time someone communicated with you in a way that felt unprofessional (too stiff or too casual). What specifically made it feel that way?
3. What's your honest, realistic response-time window for client messages, given school and other commitments — and how would you word that as one sentence to a client?

Submission Instructions

Save your completed proposal draft and your five answers to the Knowledge Checks in the same Google Doc or Notion page. Share the link (or download link) with your instructor before the next class. Keep this proposal — you will use its structure directly in Lesson 8's Client Simulation.